

FARO — User guide

Book 2 of 3 · For whoever uses FARO

Prototype version: September 2026 · SHIFT 2026 Challenge · Gamification

How to read this book

This guide describes FARO as it is built today: six tabs, two contextual screens and a Canvas integration that can run in two modes. Each chapter covers one screen: what it shows, what every control does, and **the exact rule that decides what you see**. When a rule has a number (a threshold, a score, a percentage), the number is the one in the code.

If you only have five minutes, read chapter 1 and chapter 5. They are the reason FARO exists.

The two modes

FARO can run on test data or on your real Canvas. The difference changes no screen; it changes where the data comes from.

Mode	What you see	How to recognise it
Simulated	A sample course (<i>Gestión de Proyectos</i> , 6 modules, 16 activities) with a student who has not logged in for 5 days.	In Profile → Canvas the badge says <i>Simulated</i> .
Live	Your real Canvas course, your modules, your submissions.	The badge says <i>Live</i> and your course name appears.

In *Live* mode FARO never talks to Canvas directly: it goes through its own server, which holds the credential. That is explained in Book 1 (Security) and set up by following Book 3 (Technical documentation).

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Hard to quit. Easy to return. No Game Over. Recalculate your route.

1. What FARO is

FARO is a companion for people who study online while they work. It does not teach the course: Canvas does that. What FARO does is answer three questions Canvas does not.

- **What do I do now?** One single next step, sized to the time you actually have.
- **How do I come back?** When you have been away, a new route instead of a list of overdue work.
- **Am I alone in this?** Other people working on the same thing, without having to talk to anyone.

The product promise is short: **hard to quit, easy to return.**

What it is NOT

Worth saying, because it defines the rest of the guide:

- **It is not a video game.** It uses game mechanics, but there are no lives, no levels, no Game Over.
- **It is not a social network.** No followers, no ranking, no way to see who is ahead.
- **It does not replace Canvas.** Your grades, submissions and dates still live there. FARO only reads.
- **It is not a to-do list.** On no screen will you see "you have 14 overdue activities".

Navigation

Six tabs at the bottom (or on the left when the window is wide). **FARO sits in the middle, raised:** it is the piece that connects everything else.

Tab	Answers
Home	Where am I and what do I do now?
Journey	Where am I going?
FARO	The mentor: explains, organises, accompanies
Community	Who is with me?
Rewards	Your FARO points
Progress	What you have built

Two more screens are not tabs and appear when needed: **Recovery**, which opens from Home when you come back from an absence, and **Profile**, which opens from Community. They are kept out of the bar on purpose — FARO must not feel like yet another app with sections to manage.

2. First use: your destination

The first time you open FARO there are no tabs. Only three questions. Until you answer them there is nothing else — without a destination, FARO has nothing to plan with.

Step 1 — Why are you studying?

Eight options: career growth, better income, career change, a promotion, finish my degree, personal achievement, personal development, something else.

You pick one. It is not a personality test or a psychological formula: it is personalisation. There will be a week when you don't feel like opening the course, and this is what FARO will remind you of.

Step 2 — What would finishing it let you do?

A free text field. In your words, one line is enough. The example it shows: *"Lead my own projects instead of just executing them."*

That text later appears in Home, Journey and Progress as your destination. It is optional, but it is the part that makes the rest feel yours rather than a system's.

Step 3 — How much time do you really have?

Five options: **10, 20, 30, 45 or 60 minutes** a day.

This is the step that changes FARO's behaviour the most. It is not an aspiration, it is a budget:

- The Next Best Step is chosen among the activities that **fit** in that time.
- Recovery's feasibility check compares the minutes the course demands against the ones you declared.
- The recovery route is packed into days of that size.

If you put 60 because it sounds good and you only have 20, FARO will plan a week you cannot keep. Be honest before ambitious: that is why the screen says it in those words.

Afterwards

Your destination sits on a dark card with your goal and your sentence. Below it, the time chips stay editable: **you can change your available time whenever you want**, and everything else recalculates on its own.

To come back to this screen later: **Progress** → tap your destination card, at the bottom.

3. Home

Answers a single question: **where am I and what do I do now?** It is ordered top to bottom by what matters most.

1. Header

A greeting by time of day, the course name, the progress bar and the percentage. Tapping it opens Journey.

Top right, in the app bar, is your **momentum** with its percentage. It is always visible, on every screen.

2. Attention strip (only when it applies)

If FARO detected an interruption, a tappable strip appears:

- **Amber, "Welcome back"** — when you return after an absence. Opens Recovery.
- **White, with an attention message** — when your rhythm dropped but you did not leave. Opens the same.

If you are on track, nothing appears. FARO does not interrupt to congratulate you.

3. Next Best Step

The dark card. **One single activity**, never a list. It shows the name, the estimated minutes, the minutes you said you have, and a line explaining why it is that one.

How it is chosen (the full rule, deliberately boring):

1. Take the open activities: the missed ones, the current one and the upcoming ones.
2. Of those, the ones that **fit in your available time**.
3. Of those, **the shortest**.
4. If none fits, the shortest of all, and the text tells you to start it and pause whenever you want.

The reason changes by case. If the step is overdue: *"This step reopens the route. Everything after it gets easier."*

Start this step marks it as completed and moves everything at once: progress, momentum, journey, points and badges. **Ask FARO** opens the Mentor.

4. Community card

One line with how many people are studying your course right now. It only appears if there is someone. Opens Community.

5. The four pillars

Focus (your purpose) · **Advance** (the journey) · **Reward** (progress) · **Own** (the mentor). They are shortcuts, not new sections.

6. Your courses, momentum, rhythm and achievements

Tappable summary cards. **Momentum** carries a word instead of just the number: *strong momentum* (65% or more), *regaining momentum* (40–64%), *your progress is safe* (under 40%). That last one never says you are doing badly.

Safe harbour

If you activated a planned pause from Recovery, Home is replaced by a single card saying your progress is exactly where you left it, with a button to continue whenever you want. No countdown, no reminders.

4. Journey

Answers **where am I going?** It is the course as a route, not as a list.

Recalculation strip

At the top, when your route drifted: *"Recalculating your route... Nothing was lost: the route below reorders itself around where you actually are."*

It is the GPS metaphor and it is literal: the route reorders, you are not scolded.

The route

Every activity is a stop, grouped by module. The state shows in the dot on the left:

State	How it looks	What it means
Completed	Green dot	Submitted
You are here	Mint dot with a halo	Your current position
Missed	Hollow amber dot	Overdue and still open — never in red
Upcoming	Grey dot	Not yet
Locked	Dimmed text	Opens later

The stops that close a module are **checkpoints**: the dot becomes square and the label appears. They are the "you made it this far" moments.

Each stop carries its minutes and its date in plain language: *due today, due in 3 days, was due 2 days ago*. Never a count of how many you owe.

The rest of this screen

- **Header** with the percentage and, if you wrote it, your destination.
- **Next Best Step**, the same one as in Home — it is the same data, not a copy.
- **Your way back**, only if the route is recalculated: three short sessions.
- **One social line**, discreet: how many people worked on this module this week. Opens Community. It is one line on purpose — Journey is not a feed.

5. Recovery

The screen FARO exists for. It opens from the Home strip, or from SOS in Community.

The rule that orders everything: you are never shown everything you owe before being shown how you can finish.

The order, and why it is that one

1. Checking your progress... — one second. Skipped if your system has reduced motion.

2. Welcome back. *"Your progress is still here. FARO recalculated your route."* Below, in small print: *"You were away 5 days."* It is a fact, not a reproach. It will never say "you lost 5 days".

2b. Reconnect in 2 minutes — if you have been away 3 or more days, a violet card appears: *"Three questions on what you saw last."* It is optional (*Not now* is always one tap away) and **it is not a test:** it does not count towards your grade and nobody else sees your answers.

When you start, the cards take the whole screen, one at a time, with three large options and a progress bar at the top (● ● ○):

- The questions are about **the modules you already worked on**, latest first. Never about something you have not seen.
- If you are right, the option turns green and the explanation appears.
- If you are wrong, the card shakes, the option is struck through, the key idea appears and **you try again**. There is no way to "lose".
- When the three are done: *"You are reconnected. You remembered 2 of 3 first time and reviewed the rest."* and **+75 points**, for finishing, not for first-try answers.

Only one set of cards is rewarded per day. Afterwards, the top of the screen keeps the mark *Reconnected today · +75 points*.

Why before the numbers? Because after days away, the first thing you need is not a plan but proof that you still remember something. Two minutes you can succeed at, before seeing how much is left.

3. Your current situation — three numbers, not eighteen lines: days until the close, remaining work in hours, modules left.

4. Feasibility — the honest answer to *can I still finish?* Four possible answers:

Verdict	When it appears	What it says
Yes, you can finish	What is required fits comfortably in your time	Green, with the min/day needed
You can finish by picking up the pace	It needs a bit more than you sustain	Amber, with both numbers

Verdict	When it appears	What it says
Your original route is no longer realistic	It does not reach	Dark green, not red, and offers alternatives
FARO needs more information	No close date or no history	It does not guess

The gauge compares what the course demands against what you sustain. The vertical line is 100%: crossing it means you are being asked for more than you said you have.

That third verdict is deliberate. FARO would rather tell you it does not reach and offer a shorter plan than cheer you on with something it cannot sustain.

5. What happened? — optional, and it changes what FARO asks of you:

If you choose...	FARO...
I have less time	Shrinks your sessions to 10 minutes
I'm overwhelmed	Hides the pile and leaves you a single step
I don't understand the material	Offers to take you to the Mentor
I lost my routine	Prepares a comeback mission
I need a break	Activates the safe harbour
I'm ready to continue	Resumes the route

None changes dates or academic rules. The screen says so at the bottom, in those words.

6. How much time do you have? — 15, 30, 45, 60 min/day or **it varies every day**. That last one is the important one for an adult with an unpredictable schedule: it produces a flexible plan with a minimum goal, a recommended one and optional extra time.

7. Route options — three paces over the same work: **Comfortable, Balanced, Intensive**. Each says how many days it needs and how much slack it leaves, computed, not promised. At most one carries **Suggested for you**, and only when there is an objective reason: it is the closest to what you already sustain. None is called "the best".

8. Your new route — the first three days, with a button to see the rest. If something does not fit before the close, an amber notice says so: FARO does not hide the work that does not reach.

9. Why did FARO change your route? — collapsible. The five inputs of the calculation. The AI is not a black box.

10. Today's one thing — one action. If it is longer than your sessions, the text acknowledges it: *"Start it and pause when you need to — moving forward counts."*

11. After completing it — *"Done. You are back on route."* with your new momentum, and two exits: continue on the Journey or reconnect with the Community. Coming back to the course and coming back to people are two different returns.

Recalculating

Every time you change the time or the pace, **"Recalculating your route..."** appears and then **"Your route was updated"**. It is not decoration: the plan below is genuinely rebuilt.

6. FARO Mentor

The **FARO** tab. A chat, but not a generic chatbot: it only knows about your course and is built to guide you, not to do the work for you.

How to use it

It opens with a message that already knows your situation — different if you are back from an absence than if you are on track. Below every reply there are **follow-up chips**: tapping them sends that question without typing it. It is the fastest way to use it.

Type freely or use the chips. It understands questions about: what to do now, being behind, having little time, not understanding something, not feeling like it, and planning the week.

The five styles

At the top, as chips: **Direct, Encouraging, Detailed, Friendly, Challenge me**.

They change how it talks to you, never what it can do. "Challenge me" will not give you answers that "Encouraging" refuses; it just sounds different. The academic and safety rules are the same across all five.

What it knows about you — exactly

This is the complete list, and it is built in a single file of the code:

- The course name
- Your progress percentage
- Your next activity and how long it takes
- Your goal and your destination sentence
- The minutes you said you have
- Your momentum and your internal friction state
- The style and language you chose

What it never receives: your name, your email, your photo, your bio, your Canvas identifiers, your grades, your history of previous conversations. If a piece of data is not built in that file, the mentor never sees it. It is not a written policy: it is the only way it can receive data.

What it will not do

If you ask it to solve graded work, it refuses — and offers to break it into steps, explain the concept or review your reasoning. That refusal is the same across the five styles.

At the bottom of the screen is the note that says so without small print.

7. Community

Answers **who is with me?** It is a digital campus, not a social network. It is ordered by need, not by novelty.

1. Presence

The dark green strip with a pulsing dot: how many people are studying your course now, how many are enrolled, how many are in rooms.

They are **counts, never people**. And since nobody appears by name, neither do you: the screen says so explicitly.

2. Your profile

A button with your avatar. Opens Profile.

3. I'm stuck (SOS)

The amber button. It is the piece that best explains FARO: **three kinds of stuck, three different systems**.

If you say...	FARO takes you to...	Because...
I don't understand the topic	Mentor	You need an explanation
I don't know how to organise my time	Recovery	You need a plan
I want to talk to someone	Community	You need people

FARO does not answer every problem the same way, and Community is the answer to only one of the three.

4. Ask the community

Four kinds: **Question, I'm stuck, Something I learned, Tip**. Optional title, required text. It is posted with the context of your course and current module, so whoever answers knows what you are talking about.

5. Study rooms

Studying accompanied **without talking to anyone**. Each room shows a name, course, how many are inside, duration and mode: **quiet** or **pomodoro**.

When you join, the room takes the whole screen: a large clock, the avatars of those with you, and a line saying nobody sees whether you were productive — only that you were accompanied.

Joining gives no points. Finishing does. On completing the session: *"You studied alongside 5 people"* and +20 FARO points.

You can also **create a room** of 15, 25, 30, 45 or 60 minutes.

In the prototype the clock runs fast (one second per minute) so a full session can be shown. The screen says so.

6. Community mission

A collective goal for the week — for example, 500 activities between everyone. Your bar adds to everyone's. **Nobody competes**: when it is completed, everyone who took part receives recognition, regardless of how much each contributed.

7. The feed

Filters: All, Asking for help, Questions, Learnings.

How it is ordered — and this is the most important thing on the screen: **reactions do not count**. The order is decided by relevance to your course and module, whether someone is stuck and unanswered, and how recent it is. A post with forty reactions and one with zero rank the same if they are equally relevant to you.

And someone asking for help weighs **more** than someone celebrating an achievement. Landing on a front page full of other people's wins is the worst welcome for someone having a hard time.

Reactions are about learning, not popularity:

	Means
	I like it
	You did it
	It helped me
	It motivates me
	I'm with you

They are shown **separately**, never summed into a single number. "12 applauses" says what happened; "12 likes" would be a scoreboard.

Each kind of post offers the reactions that serve it: someone asking for help is offered *I'm with you*, not applause.

Replies. Tap the counter to open the thread. Every reply carries its origin: **Peer answer, from the instructor** or **FARO explanation**. A peer answer with forty helpful marks **is still** a peer answer, and the thread says so. There is also **Report** on every post.

8. Rewards and Progress

FARO gives points for **persisting**, not for clicking. Everything that awards points requires something real to have happened: an activity finished, a module closed, a return after disconnecting, three review cards completed, an answer that helped someone.

How points are earned

Action	Points	Exact rule
Complete an activity	50	Every completed activity on the route: submitted in Canvas or finished in FARO.
Close a module	250	When every activity in the module is completed.
Rhythm bonus	+25	Every 3 consecutive days with activity. If the streak breaks it stops adding; it never subtracts.
Comeback bonus	+125	Once, when you return after 3 or more days without activity and complete something.
Review cards	+75	For finishing the three cards (not for getting them right first time). Once a day.
Answer marked helpful	+25	Another student marked your answer as helpful in Community.
Finish a study room	+100	Joining gives nothing. Finishing the full session does.

The scale is built for a **semester**, not a course: finishing a whole course is worth 2,300–2,800 points, and a semester of about four courses reaches 10,000.

The Rewards screen

1. Your points this semester. The big number adds up this course and the semester's previous courses. It counts up when you open the screen, and below it shows what you earned this week (+250 *this week*).

2. Your next reward. One track to **\$200 MXN** (10,000 points), with marks at \$50 and \$100. It says how far is left and what finishing the current course is worth: *"Finishing Gestión de Proyectos is worth at least 1,450 more points."* The **Keep going** button takes you to the Journey: the reward always points back at the course.

3. Semester rewards. Three tiers:

Reward	Points
\$50 MXN	2,500
\$100 MXN	5,000
\$200 MXN	10,000

Tiers are **not bought: they unlock**. Reaching 5,000 spends nothing. You decide when to redeem, and **redeeming closes the semester's reward at that tier**. Before you redeem a lower tier, FARO says it in those words: *"If you keep going, you can reach \$200 MXN."* It is your decision, not a trap.

4. Where they come from. The breakdown for this course (activities, modules, rhythm, comeback, cards, community) and for the semester's previous courses.

When you reach 10,000, the card changes to **Reward unlocked!** with the button to redeem \$200 MXN.

In the prototype all of this is simulated: the amounts, the semester's previous courses and redemption. The screen says so with a tag and in the footer. In production, the institution sets and funds the reward.

Resilience achievements

There are five. None is earned by opening the app.

Achievement	Earned when
The Comeback	You return after 3 or more days without activity and complete an activity.
Back on Track	You have at least 2 recorded sessions and your momentum is back to 65% or more.
Weathered the Storm	You complete a session while having 2 or more overdue activities when you started it.
Smart Session	You complete a session that fitted in the time you declared you had.
Finisher	Your progress reaches 100%.

While an achievement is not earned, FARO shows a **hint** of what it would take. Never a reproach.

Community recognitions

Recognition	Earned when
Community Builder	You take part in the course space consistently.
Knowledge Sharer	You share resources or notes that others use.
Helpful Peer	Your answers accumulate helpful marks.
Study Companion	You complete study rooms alongside others.
Community Comeback	You come back to the community after a period away.

Progress

The progress percentage is **not invented by FARO**: it comes from Canvas. It is activities with a recorded submission ÷ total course activities. An overdue date does not count as "done", and an activity that belongs to no module does not enter the count.

Momentum is different from progress: it measures current connection to learning, over a 14-day window, with a floor of 20. It never drops to zero. Progress once earned is never lost.

Every time you earn points, a short notice appears at the top (*+50 points*) and fades on its own.

9. Profile

How to get there

Two ways, both valid:

1. **From Community** — tap your avatar or your name on the presence card, above the feed. It opens your public profile: what others see of you.
2. **From the bottom menu** — the Profile tab, next to Rewards.

What is inside

Section	What it holds	Who sees it
Name	The name you choose to show. Empty until you set it.	Other students in the course.
Photo	A small square image, downsized in your own browser before being saved. The original is never uploaded.	Other students in the course.
Bio	One line, optional.	Other students in the course.
Language	Spanish or English. Changes the whole interface and also the language the Mentor answers in.	Only you.
Mentor style	Direct, encouraging, detailed, friendly or challenge me.	Only you.
Your destination	The purpose you declared at the start, editable.	Only you.
Available time	The minutes per day you said you have. Change it when your life changes: it recalculates the whole route.	Only you.
Institutional account	State of the link with Tecmilenio. Labelled as simulated in the prototype: there is no real SSO yet.	Only you.
Canvas	Technical panel: active mode (<i>Simulated</i> or <i>Live</i>), identified course, endpoints queried, refused scopes and a live request log. In <i>Live</i> mode it also says which backend the calls go through and whether activity is being derived from your submissions.	Only you.

Profile rules

- **Nothing from the profile travels to the Mentor.** Not the name, not the photo, not the bio. The context the Mentor receives is built elsewhere and does not read this file.

- **Everything is stored locally** in the prototype. In production, the FARO backend is the source of truth so it can sync across devices.
- **Nothing is mandatory.** You can use the whole of FARO without a name or photo. You will appear with your initials.
- **Classmates never have a photo** in the prototype: only initials and a colour. Only your own avatar can carry an image.
- **There is no follower count, no level, no ranking.** The avatar colour is decoration, not status.

10. Rules FARO never breaks

These are not design preferences. They are limits written in the code, and any new feature has to respect them.

- 1. There is no Game Over.** No system state kicks you out of the course, locks content for inactivity or erases progress. The worst possible scenario is *"recalculating your route"*.
- 2. Progress is not lost.** Not for missing a day, not for missing three weeks. Breaking a streak stops *adding*; it never *subtracts*.
- 3. We never show you a risk score.** Internally the system computes friction states to decide how to help you. You will never see "dropout risk: 87%". You will see "your route needs attention" and a concrete action.
- 4. When you come back, we do not greet you with the debt.** Never "you have 14 overdue activities". First "welcome back, your progress is still here", then a route.
- 5. FARO does not do your graded work.** The Mentor explains, gives hints, organises and accompanies. If you ask it to solve an exam or write your submission, it refuses and offers help so you can do it yourself.
- 6. The Mentor sees only eleven fields.** Course, progress, next activity, estimated time, your declared goal, your destination in your words, available time, momentum, friction state, style and language. It does not see your name, your email, your grades, your photo or your full history.
- 7. FARO does not write to Canvas.** The permission to submit grades exists in the LTI standard and we explicitly refuse it. Canvas is the academic source of truth; FARO only reads.
- 8. FARO does not change dates or academic rules.** It can reorganise *your personal* study plan. The course deadlines are set by the institution and only it can move them.
- 9. If you are not going to make it, we tell you.** The verdict "not realistic" exists on purpose. FARO would rather offer you the best possible scenario and a conversation with your instructor than promise something it cannot sustain.
- 10. There are no leaderboards.** Community shows aggregate presence ("23 studying now"), never "Andrea has been at it for 37 minutes". The feed orders by usefulness for learning, not by reactions: a request for help weighs more than an achievement.
- 11. No badge spam.** Five resilience achievements and five community recognitions. All require having persisted through something. None is earned by clicking.
- 12. FARO must not become another burden.** If a feature makes the product heavier, slower, more confusing or more invasive without improving persistence, it is not implemented.

Hard to quit. Easy to return. No Game Over. Recalculate your route.